

try. If the spirit of competitiveness is not there, you are going to struggle. I feel that the competitive spirit has played a huge role in making me what I am. There have been tough situations but you still go out and you want to do something which may not have an impact on that game but it may have an impact on the series. You look at the bigger picture. If you do that, then you start approaching tough times differently.

**Q. Have you ever doubted yourself, known fear or insecurity?**

A. Whenever I'm injured... those phases were quite difficult. All the injuries I had were related to my batting style or batting grip... Whether it was

Before that we'd drawn three test matches and this was the last Test and Pakistan was in a good position. I think that has to be it.

**Q. A lot has changed in Indian cricket since you made your debut. What about Indian cricket has not changed in all these years which disappoints you?**

A. Most things have changed now, and I don't think that at this stage I have any complaints. Right now if I have to say then maybe the only thing which needs to be looked into is providing facilities to players who are in rural areas to spread the game as much as possible and provide equal opportunity to everyone playing it.

cause it is exciting. They don't understand the game, but the atmosphere is such that they want to be part of it and it is fantastic for the game.

**Q. Take your son—is he going to take to Tests when there's the glamour of T20 around?**

A. Arjun actually likes both, he wants to wear whites and hit sixes. So it's a combination of both. I keep telling him that when you wear coloured clothing you can hit the ball up into the air and when you wear whites you have to keep the ball on the ground. I basically want him to enjoy the game more than anything else—if he enjoys the game then he is willing to go to any extents to achiev-

"I would not let my natural instincts get confused by unwanted thoughts. I went ahead and played my game."

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"There have been tough situations. But you want to go out there and give it your best. You look at the bigger picture."



tennis elbow or a finger injury, or bicep and shoulder, all of that is needed for you to have the right bat swing and things like that. Even during recovery time I worked very hard. I had to be patient and take things as they came. That was tough.

**Q. What is the toughest thing you've done on a cricket field? That you're most proud of?**

A. Well, I'm proud that on my first tour to Pakistan I continued batting after being hit on the nose by Waqar. When I came back, I realised that I'd broken my nose and we managed to save that Test match. We were 34 for 4 with almost a-day-and-a-half to go.

**Q. Twenty20 has caught everyone's fancy. Do you worry that kids won't want to learn basic skills because those are not going to be used in T20...**

A. Well I'd say probably even Test cricket is changing. It's just progression; the game has changed and that's fine, I feel it's fine as long as Test cricket doesn't get neglected. The innovations are going to be there. Now in one-day cricket people play over the keeper's head and and play reverse sweep to fast bowlers. It makes the game exciting, it's fast. For Test cricket you get a different crowd. For T20 there are so many who come be-

ing his target.

**Q. Do you think coaches of the future will really want to teach Test skills to kids who are going to come to the game in the next 10 years?**

A. I think it's extremely important for coaches to be teaching kids the right techniques, the right fundamentals. There are different kind of skills - to leave a ball outside the off-stump and to know where your off stump is, is an art. As long as we respect formats and just keep our thoughts and expectations for that particular format, we should be okay. It's good to be multi-dimensional, you earn money out of it and you live your passion.